

our database. It is company policy. I don't think there is any other Linux distribution that does that.

Another thing is that we let our customers manage their infrastructure for free. Red Hat charges on Red Hat Network Satellite and also has a pre-server fee.

Q This premier backporting feature comes at an extra price tag or is it a part of the regular pricing?

This feature is charged for. Generically, we have a price for one and two CPU machines, and those greater than two. We have two levels—one with lifetime premium backporting support, and the other without it. We also have one for only updates. Here, you can't call us. Now, Red Hat has service 5 days a week, during working hours (12/5, as against 24/7), which we don't have. We think that if you are going to run a production-level server, you should always have 24/7 support. How can you say, "Oh! the bug is not big enough, you can only call us during those hours." From our perspective, that's not acceptable. So we have 24/7 offerings only. All prices are on the Web so you can check it for yourself. We have all that they have, but our prices will pretty much be half of theirs. There's no apples and oranges' comparison here. We have premium backporting and lifetime support that they don't. We have 24/7 support, and they don't.

Q What kind of support structure is there for non-Oracle customers who are only buying OEL and not typical Oracle products?

We think you are still an Oracle customer because you are buying Oracle Linux. We don't differentiate among our customers; the process is the same. However, the interesting thing about Linux is that our Oracle support organisation has a deep knowledge of databases, middleware and all that. So, if you identify a filesystem bug, who do you call? Do you call the operating system vendor or the database vendor -- because it's a perfect line between those two?

The database is messing with the filesystems and the operating system kind of controls the filesystem. The Linux vendors don't know about databases, and the database vendor doesn't know about Linux. It's hard to find that level of skills in this area. When you call Oracle, we have support engineers with access to the database, along with others with a Linux background. Our Linux guy says, "Alright, if you're doing this in the database, it can trigger those filesystem issues." So, we are able to answer those questions much faster, just because of the availability of the knowledge inside Oracle. Therefore, the value we offer a customer is "Don't worry, from the database to all the way down, you call us; it's our headache to sort out the problem." There is extreme value in that.

Q In these times of an economic meltdown, do you see more migration towards Linux and open source?

Yes, exactly! You are paying the same, but the expectations are much higher. So, the business is getting squeezed. How to deal with that? The solution is to bring the same value, but at a much lower price point, and that's where the strength of

Linux comes in. If you look at the financial industry, they were going for big-boxes because that's how they look to scale out as they had plenty of money. Well, the situation is different now, and we see a lot more proof of concepts and a lot more deployment projects. There are a lot of small projects that are precursors to much larger projects. And, we see a significant number of those happening now; of course, the existing Oracle stack of solutions is still there.

Q For your team, is it the market you're after or the development community? For example, there is a team in IBM that taps the development community, and there is another team looking at the business side of it.

Oracle has a team focused on developers. The goal of my team, on the other hand, is to sort of blanket the world with Linux. So, my focus is on the business side. However, in this specific field, developers also play an influential role. They influence the decision makers.

And obviously there is Oracle's strong commitment and history. If you want to go with other operating systems like Solaris or AIX, we still offer support as Oracle. But this is the strategic direction we are going in and I must add that some of our products get released for Linux before any other systems. Our developers internally develop on Linux, so there's quite a lot of momentum there. There is something called Oracle on Demand, where Oracle runs an Oracle customer's Oracle software for them—we run that on Linux. So, we trust Linux that much.

Q What kind of challenges do you see in people migrating to Linux?

The human brain is amazing—in the future, people always do what they have done in the past; not everything, but a significant number of things, nonetheless. If they have always bought large UNIX boxes, they will think, "Of course, I will buy UNIX boxes."

Now, the economic downturn is helping us. People are now not going for those expensive boxes. They are looking for other ways. And clearly we are the leaders in the other way, because Oracle has been doing clusters and bridges for a very long time. Therefore, combing the human brain with some flexibilities, in addition to the economic downturn are creating opportunities for us.

Q What if someone is not interested in Oracle? Say they are using other databases like MySQL or PostgreSQL, but they want to go with OEL? Do you have the expertise in handling the issues of such a customer?

Sure, we support whatever ships with the RHEL Advanced platform, which even includes GFS (Global File System). We have our own OCFS (Oracle Cluster File System). However, whatever they ship, we support. We are a database company, so we can obviously support a database query. 

An interview by the LFY Bureau folks.